

The Lair of the Evil Dragon

—“Come, hurry, Borān, Varaz is already waiting for us. There he is.”

Why is he sitting with his head in his hands?

—“Varaz, what’s wrong?”

He doesn’t immediately answer, but just lets out a big sigh. They all look at each other and then to the *Bāmbishn*. But auntie, as usual, remains stoic.

—“Varaz?!”

He looks up, shaking his head.

—“Children, what to do? I was going to tell you a riveting story of the Princess and her Knight. But then something awful happened! Awful! Awful! Awful!”

—“Oh, no, Varaz, what happened?”

—“It’s the Princess!”

She grabs her sister’s hand. She sometimes gets too involved in these stories.

—“The Princess!! What happened?”

—“They took her!”

—“Who?”

—“Those evil *Ḥazār*.”

—“But how, Varaz? Why didn’t she stop them with her magic? And the Knight!?”

—“Those wicked *Ḥazār*, they put a potion in the Knight’s wine, and now his arms and legs are paralyzed.”

—“Parallellized,” *Āzar* sticks out both her arms in front of her, “like this?”

—“No, ha, ha, that is parallel. Paralyzed is more like this,” he let his arms drop along his side, “see, you cannot move them at all.”

—“But the Princess has the antidote to . . . to unpara . . . wise him, no?”

—“That’s just it. The *Ḥazār*, they took her. She cannot help the poor Knight.”

—“But . . . but, with her magic, Varaz!”

—“Alas, children, the *Ḥazār* have this one spell that makes princesses swoon and sway. And no matter how a princess may try,” he moves forward as if to whisper to them, “it’s a love potion!”

—“But she loves the Knight!”

—“Well, this potion is so potent, that its victim forgets all and everyone! And now, they took her, our poor princess.”

—“Varaz, what spell does a thing like that?”

—“Well, perhaps I should not say it out loud,” pointing at the girls, “we have princesses here too and if that spell. . . , *āy wāy!*”

—“Come Varaz, just whisper it.”

—“Okay, the *Ḫazār* incantation to swoon princesses is *Shu...*,” he pretends to look at the girls to see the effect of the spell, “...ri... shad.”

He pauses for the inevitable to happen.

—“Shurishad!”

Ha, ha, you always can count on Shirowe.

—“Oh, no, Shirowe! What did you do? The princesses! Now you made them cursed!,” he goes to the cushion where the three girls are sitting, “are you girls okay?”

Is she? Or is she letting the story get to her head? That stupid Shirowe!

—“I think. . . ”

—“I don’t feel anything! A stupid curse like that is not going to get me!”

She looks at her friend, who jumps up and stands with her hands in her hips, defiantly.

—“Well, perhaps, it’s because, . . . , you’re not a princess, Abrangih.”

—“I am, Borān!,” oops, now she made her friend angry, “How can you say that!!”

The thing is, she once overheard the *darigbed* tell one of the pages that her friend Abrangih, that she is a bastard child. And while she doesn’t exactly know what that means. . .

—“But your daddy was no King.”

—“How . . . how dare you, Borān! I . . . My gra. . . I . . . I am a princess!!”

While stammering, she stamps her little foot down on the ground, but doesn’t say anything anymore and sits down again. The girl who knows about that castle in far Yemen now claims to be a princess? Who *pad Yazdān* [by the gods] is she? Could it be she is related to his friend *Ḫorra-Ḫosrow* from that place? He has to find out. But so far, all his attempts to talk to her have failed as she always comes a little late and leaves right after he finishes his storytelling.

—“Okay, just to be sure that you girls are alright, *Āzar* dear, come sit on my lap,” a bit hesitantly, she obeys. He looks straight into her face and then yawns a couple of times. There is another thing you always can count on, ha, ha: she now yawns too, “*Pargast*, looks like the spell might be getting to her! She’s falling a sleep!”

She jumps up, indignant.

—“No, I am not! I wanna hear what happened to the Princess!”

—“*Alā*, looks like we’re out of the woods, children. Our princesses are okay. I guess, it only works if the spell weaver is *Ḥazār*.”

—“But I am *Ḥazār*!,” and a third thing you could always count on: Shirowe would grab every opportunity to mention his exalted pedigree, “My great grandmother was the Princess of the *Ḥazār*.”

—“Aha, one sixteenth *Ḥazār*! Now I get it. That’s why little *Āzar* was yawning. Shirowe’s spell had some effect, but luckily nothing at all like it had on our poor Princess.”

—“Varaz, what does that *shu-shu* spell mean?”

—“I have it on good authority that,” whispering once more, “*Shurishad* means ‘the White Prince Who Swoops the Princess of her Feet’.”

—“But the Knight is who the Princess loves! He has to rescue her!”

—“Remember the potion. Paralyzed,” he shakes once more his head, “Children, could this then be the end of our intrepid duo?!”

—“Oh, no, someone has to rescue her, Varaz!”

—“You’re right, now that are duo are out of commission, we need a third hero. But who will be our third?”

He pretends to ponder over this question, but he gets the desired result pretty quickly.

—“The Captain, Varaz, the Captain has to rescue her. Like they rescued him! Remember, from the lion!”

—“Ah, yes, the Captain! Why didn’t I think of that?! *Spās* [thanks], *Āzar*. But, how are we going to let him know what happened?”

A conundrum that his young audience has no immediate solution for. Good, for he has his own.

—“How, Varaz?”

—“I thing I know just the think! Oops, I said that wrong, ha, ha,” mistakes are just funny jokes in disguise, “I *think* I know just the *thing*: The horns of Iskander!”

—“Huh? What are they?”

⌈This was a long time ago, when great Iskander [Alexander] conquered Egypt, the high priest invited Iskander to consult the oracle of their God, AMON-RA. And the god AMON-RA was pleased with Iskander’s reign and to show that he was the new *Shāhān-Shāh* of Egypt, AMON-RA gave him a couple of golden horns. And so, from that day onwards,

Iskander wore the sacred vestments: the purple robe, and cloven sandals, and the horns of AMON-RA, as if he was the god himself.¹⁹ 𐤀

—“So, children, the horns of Iskander, that’s what we’re going to use to warn the Captain. But those horns, where did we put them?”

—“You have Iskander’s horns, Varaz?”

—“Me? No, I doubt it, but perhaps...,” he looks around, pretending to think, “perhaps, you guys do?”

—“We??”

—“Well, I have a question for you guys.”

—“Yeah?”

—“Your daddy? Is he not the *Shāhān-Shāh*?”

—“Of course, silly!”

—“Of Persia?”

—“Of Erān!”

Oh, yes, he forgot that’s how they call their own country.

—“Sooo...,” he draws out the suspense, “then you are the progeny of the *Shāhān-Shāh* of Erān!”

No one really knows what that word means, but they all can guess.

—“Yes, we are!”

She glances at Abrangih, but her friend has moved away and is now sitting on her own, sulking.

—“So, then you guys are the heirs of *Shāhān-Shāh* Iskander, for he too was the *Shāhān-Shāh* of Erān. And therefore, you guys must have the horn!”

—“We do? Daddy never gave it to us.”

—“He doesn’t have to. I see the horns right in your hands, Āzar.”

The girl looks surprised at her empty hands.

—“There is nothing there, Varaz.”

—“Oh no, there isn’t? Let me see, if you take your left hand to your mouth and pout it like so,” he cups his hand and brings it to his mouth, “And then your right hand, against it as well. Look guys, I think we have ourselves a horn of Iskander. Right, Āzar?”

She starts to hoot and everyone know starts imitating her.

—“Okay, guys. We’re all going to do it together, so that it can be heard on all seven seas. Ready... and *hooter-a-tooter*. I think it works.”

𐤀 The Captain says

¹⁹Ephippus of Olynthus.

~“Oh, listen! The horn is blown. That means supper is ready. Good, I was kind of getting hungry.”⁷¹

—“Okay, guys, we need to do it one more time: *hooter-a-tooter!*”

⌈The Captian looks up.

~“Oh, no, the horn sounds twice. That’s not good! It means it’s going to rain tomorrow!”⁷¹

—“Children, I think we still have to do it one more time, but as loud as we can, okay,” they all stand up and start hooting and tooting as loud as they can, “great, I think we got it, children.”

⌈The Captain jumps up.

~“*Āy wāy*, the horn has sounded trice! That means grave danger has befallen my friends. Sailors, ready the ship, we are setting sail forthwith!” Okay, we did it. Now the Captain has been alerted and when he arrives, the people tell him what happened. How *χazār* magic has taken their beloved Princess away. And the Captain promises them that he will bring her back. Now, he first has to find her!⁷¹

—“Where did they take her, Varaz?”

—“Indeed, where would those wicked *χazār* have taken the Princess? Where would their secret hide-out be? Okay, guys. There is one place the Captain has heard of. But it’s a bit of a secret. So shh, don’t tell anyone, perhaps...,” he looks straight at Shirowe, “*Dar band* [close the door]!”

A little puzzled, the boy nonetheless closes the door.

—“Oh, no, ha, ha, that’s not what I meant,” he got his little revenge on his detractor, “It’s the name of that secret place: Darband.”

That makes them all laugh, although Shirowe’s is more of a pretend-laugh.

—“What is it, that place, Varaz?”

—“Well, to explain, I am gonna have to tell you a story.”

⌈So, long ago, there lived two giants, Gog and Magog, in the land of the Massive Goths. It’s a land far, far away in the north. And their king was Theuderixos the Massive...⁷¹

—“Are you making fun of my ancestor, Varaz!”

The menace in Shirowe’s voice is a little unsettling, but he shrugs it off .

—“What? Oh, I see. You think, Shirowe, I was talking about the great Theuderixos [Theodoric], King of Italy and the Goths, your great, great,

great, great grandfather,” he glances at the *Bāmbishn*, who sticks up three fingers—oops, the first great was just great, ha, ha, “yep, one great ancestor. No, no. This is, as I said, long time ago, when the Goths had not been split in two.”

—“Split in two?”

—“Oh yes, the Emperor feared the might of the Goths, because they were so massive. And so he decreed that every Goth had to be sawn in two. And one half he sent to the west and the other to the east.”

—“That’s not possible, Varaz.”

—“Well, perhaps I heard that wrong, about the Wisigoths and Ostrogoths, ha, ha. But be that as it may...”

⌈It is in this land of the Massive Goths that live the two brothers, Gog and Magog. And those two, they’re always quibbling over who has the biggest stride.⌋

—“What does that mean, Varaz?”

—“Oh, who could make the biggest step with his legs.”

⌈And Gog exclaims

~“Watch me! In a single step, I will walk across the tomb of *Shāhān-Shāh* Kurosh.” Okay, let me explain. When Theudericos the Massive died, his daughter, Taumiraspenta became queen regent for her young son. And she was very pretty, so *Shāhān-Shāh* Kurosh coveted her, and also her lands. And so, he launched an army to conquer the Massive Goths. And he tricked Taumiraspenta’s son in drinking so much that he succumbed. But that made Queen Taumiraspenta so angry that, instead of marrying him, she killed the great *Shāhān-Shāh* Kurosh. And then Kurosh’s men, they built a tomb for him, as big as a house, a monument which to this day still no one has begrudged him.²⁰ And so, to Kurosh’s last resting place, the giant brothers now go. And then Gog, he..., well, you should have seen it, children, how he lifts up his one legs, swings it over the chamber of the deceased *Shāhān-Shāh*—I already told you that it’s as tall as a house, right—and ... plop... he’s over it. But then Magog says, ~“I do you one better, brother. You stepped over the *Shāhān-*

²⁰Morier, *A Journey through Persia*, p. 145.

Shāh's chamber, but I will step over his river in one single step." See, children, in the land of the Massive Goths, there is a river, and it is so big and so swift. That's why the people call it after the great *Shāhān-Shāh* Kurosh: the river Kur. And behold, Magog starts running. And the earths starts trembling under his heavy boots, and then he comes to the river and he plants his left leg firmly on one bank and then swings his right leg over its blue waters to the other side! Amazing stuff! And then Gog would find an even bigger thing to cross and then Magog would again outdo his brother, and so on. But the people of the lands of the Massive Goths got tired of the two giants always quarreling. So they asked *Shāhān-Shāh* Iskander to help them. They told him about the two giants Gog and Magog, always competing against each other, making the earth tremble with their boots.

~"Righteous double-horned Iskander, may you lift this curse from our lands, for these giants, Gog and Magog, they are spreading corruption throughout the land.²¹ They trample our crop with their silly games during the day and with their ruckus, they make our babies cry at night. Please have peace return to our lands."

~"Good people of the Massive Goths, lest you start calling me accursed, I will build a wall so high the giants will never be able to step over. And for eternity, the door will be closed for those fiends to ever disturb you again." And that's when *Shāhān-Shāh* Iskander built the Gates that keep out Gog and Magog, and the people just called it Darband.[⌈]

—"So, that's where the evil *ẖazār* took the Princess?"

—"Hmm, the Captain is not sure. See, he thinks that those *ẖazār* don't like running into Gog and Magog either. Besides, their master does not live there."

—"Where then?"

⌈High in the mountains, on a soaring high peak, in the Fortress of the Eagle. An impenetrable castle from whence there is no escape! How is the Captain even going to get in there?[⌈]

²¹Quran, 18:94.

—“But, children, it gets worse. Its master . . . Ooh, this is bad! Very bad!”

—“Who, Varaz, who is he?”

—“Oh, the vilest evil the world has ever seen. The *dewānagtum dew* [most demonic demon], the wickedest wick. . .,” he pauses to announce the next villain, one every Persian knows, “the Dragon Dahāg!”

That gets him a loud gasp.

—“Oh, no, Dahāg the Dragon!,” she wants to explain to her friend Abrangih, but she forgot that she is no longer sitting next to her. She probably knows anyway, “Varaz, nobody can defeat him. His hide is too strong, he’s invincible!”

—“It’s true,” he shakes his head, “But the Captain has to try.”

⌌ And so he prays to the Lady of the Waters. ⌌

*Grant me this, O good, most beneficent ARDWISUR ANĀHID,
that I may overcome the dragon Dahāg,
the three-mouthed, the three-headed, the six-eyed,
who has a thousand senses, that most powerful, fiendish Liar,
that demon, baleful to the world,
the strongest Liar that AHRIMAN created
against the material world,
to destroy the world of the good principle.*²²

—“Oh, Lady ANĀHID. She’s going to help him. I am sure of it!”

—“She does.”

⌌ The Goddess tells him of a ruse how to smite that evil dragon
and save the Princess. ⌌

—“A ruse?”

—“Yes, so, you all have heard the stories, right. How evil Dahāg demands every evening from his blacksmith the sacrifice of a young boy.”

It’s actually two, but one is already gruesome enough for the kids.

—“He boils his bones and then he eats his flesh!”

—“Oh, gross, Shirowe!”

Yeah, he could have done without that imagery, but that is actually how the story is told.

—“Perhaps he wants to change his menu, and have a princess or two, ha, ha.”

²²Yasht 5, §34.

Although the boy directed this to his sisters, it does have an implication in the story he had not thought of.

—“Well, children, Shirowe might be right? What if Dahāg wants to...,” he opens his mouth wide open, which makes Āzar recoil in her seat, “*āy wāy*, the Princess.”

⌈The Captain has to act quickly. So, what if, instead of a young boy, he arranges it so that Dahāg is deceived and instead eats... his own dragon spawn. By ridding the world of that demonic brood, the Good Spirit will increase and AHRIMAN’s will decrease. And AHRIMAN will be furious with Dahāg, and smite him from the top of his lair.⌋

—“Oh, that’s a smart plan. So, where are they, those dragon spawn, Varaz?”

—“The Fortress of the Eagle!”

—“Oh, no, how is the Captain going to get in there?”

—“Ah, yes. They are not *in* the fortress.”

—“But... you just said, Varaz...”

—“They are underneath it!”

—“Huh?”

—“In the tunnels beneath it.”

—“Tunnels?”

—“Yeah, the *ayār* [freedom fighter] dug those and now they like to fly around in them.”

—“The *ayār*?”

—“Ha, ha, no, the dragon spawn.”

Daddy had told him about those so-called ‘ants nests’ in Pahlav lands: fortresses built on top of a mount full with escape tunnels from which the *ayār* would stealthily fight the enemy.

⌈Evil Dahāg has chased those brave *ayār* away, so that his foul offspring could roam around in it. So, now the Captain has to get to the mountain beneath the Fortress of the Eagle. But, *pad Yazdān* [by the gods], ...⌋

He mock-shakes his head.

—“What, Varaz, what?”

—“His lair, children...”

⌈It is far, high in the mountains. What if he doesn’t get there in time? What if evil Dahāg would do something to our fair

Princess. Our Captain, he needs help!²¹

—“From the *ayār*!”

—“No. No human can travel fast enough. He needs a raptor!”

—“A what-or?”

—“It means a bird with sharp talons and mighty wings. And he knows just the beast.”

—“Which one, Varaz?”

—“The *Senmurw* [Simurg]!”

The mythical bird, who rises from her own ashes. Every boy and girl has heard about her.

—“Oh, right, she will help him. And she is the fastest.”

—“But how is he going to call her? How to call the great *Senmurw*?”

This time, it is Abrangih who provides the solution.

—“You have to dream of burning a feather and then she will come in your dream!”

Pargast [Damn], it’s exactly like what his friend *Ḫorra-Ḫosrow* from Yemen would say about the bird who comes in his dreams. Coincidence? Or proof that the girl really is from there? He has to get to that girl to find out more. But for now, it’s the story he has to get to.

—“Ooh, Abrangih is right, Borān,” her sister jumps up from excitement, “Remember, Pahrbad the musician, he always sings that song for us about burning the *Senmurw*’s feather.”

Her sister, she only needs to hear a song once, and she can sing the whole thing.

*If any trouble comes to you,
if there is talk of good and ill,
then throw my feather into fire
so that at once I’ll come to you.* ²³

—“Indeed, Āzar. What a nice song. And what a lovely voice you have,” she makes a little bow and they all clap, “And better even, children:”

⌈ The Captain just has kept one of her feathers for an emergency like this. And so, after summoning the great *Senmurw*, on the back of the noble bird, the Captain flies to the Dragon’s Lair. He dives into one of the tunnels, and before

²³Shāhnāmeḥ, 139.

the dragon spawn know it, he catches one of the fledglings. He wraps it in a black coat—for evil Dahāg wants all sacrifices to be wrapped in the darkness of his Lord AHRIMAN. And he brings it to the castle.

~“Who are you?” does Dahāg ask, “You are not the blacksmith who is supposed to bring me my daily offering.”

~“My master Kāva fell sick, Your Majestic Majesty, and he sent me, his apprentice, in his stead. Look, I am wearing his apron. . . ”[†]

—“Say, children, do you also recognize his apron? Tell me, how does it look like?”

An apron of a blacksmith? Black?

—“How would we know, Varaz?”

—“For you all have seen it!”

—“With Dahāg?”

—“No, with your daddy.”

Alright, now he is completely confusing them. Why would daddy have an apron of a blacksmith? They all look at each other, until Shirowe can no longer contain himself.

—“You guys are so dumb! You know nothing! He means our imperial standard: it’s the banner of Kāva!”

Oh, right! She forgot about that.

—“Oh, I know,” she turns to Abrangih, to explain, “with a yellow sun burning with four rays. And it is full of jewels.”

Although she doesn’t say anything, Abrangih’s eyes are shooting at her like ‘I knew that too’.

—“Well, the jewels were added later, I guess. But yes, . . .”

[†]Dahāg now recognizes the apron too.

~“Very well. Where is my offering?”

~“I come bringing you a boy, a firstborn, torn from the bosom of his mother.”

~“A first-born, har, har, har. Well done, man.” His evil laughter booms around the hall and makes the Captain cringe. But he remains steadfast. But there is someone else who tries to save the innocent.[‡]

—“Who, Varaz? Who’s going to help?”

⌈Two someones, actually. The two brides of Dahāg! In tears, they throw themselves at their husband's feet.

~"O Servant of Darkness, you ripped us from our father's hearth and made us your queens. We beg of you, do not spill more innocent blood. Let this boy live!"

~"You dumb wenches. The blood of the innocent is the sweetest of all blood. And with it, my Master will tenfold increase the Evil in this world, har, har, har." And with a gesture of disgust, he shoves the poor women onto the ground. ▮

—"Oh no, Varaz, his brides? Is she . . . the Princess?"

—"He has not yet dared to touch that pristine soul. Don't worry, Borān. Let me tell you who they are."

⌈These two brides, they are the daughters of Jam the Shining, and their names are Arenavāch and Shanghvāch. And they are the loveliest Queens in all the land—present company excluded of course, ha, ha. ▮

He glances at the *Bāmbishn*—he never can tell with her slanted eyes whether she is pretty or not. But Āzar's mommy Shirin, now that's a pretty Queen! Not something though he wants to confess to the little girl—especially as her sister will feel left out, as her mommy, well, they are both a little . . . strange, with their red hair.

—"The Captain has to save them too, Varaz!"

—"Well, first we need to get the Princess into safety, right?"

⌈And so, through evil thought, uttering evil words, Dahāg commits the evil deed and kills the boy in the black cloth. ▮

—"Oh, no, the boy!"

—"Well, that's what he thinks. But, remember, it really is his offspring."

⌈But when the little chick tries to call his procreator to stop, the Captain had given it the same poison that paralyzed the noble Knight, remember? ▮

Āzar let her arms hang limp from her shoulders

—"Yeah, that one, ha, ha."

⌈And so, the chick cannot warn fiendish Dahāg and it gets killed. But as soon as he has swallowed his victim, . . . a loud

roar bellows through the halls.

~“YOU TREACHEROUS KNAVE!,” his loud voice makes his audience cringe, “I gave you the throne of Erān and now you are doing OHRMAZD’s bidding, killing My demon!” Dahāg falls on his knees, trembling all over his scaled body.

~“But I always served You, my Dark Lord, offering You an innocent boy every evening as You commanded.”

~“Are you trying to deceive Me?! You killed one of My servants, and for that I will smite you.” But the Captain doesn’t wait. Making use of the commotion, he descends to the dungeons to go free the Princess. And now that Dahāg has been cast down, the magic of the *Shurishad* curse is undone and the Princess can think straight again.

~“O Captain my Captain, you came to save me.”

~“Just repaying my debt, dear Princess.”

~“And evil Dahāg, will he not entrance another Princess with his *ẖazār* magic?”

~“He is done for, my Princess. AHRIMAN smote him for killing one of his minions. The world has been rid of that scourge, for AHRIMAN had no compassion for his servant.”

~“It is true, Captain, that evil is most unforgiving.”⁷¹

—“And so, children, we should take a lesson from that. That Good should be all forgiving!”

She knows that he is talking about them, as he looks at her friend Abrangih and then at her. She shouldn’t have called out her friend—that’s something her brother would do, and he even didn’t do that. Now she feels awful. From now on, she is going to think of her friend as a secretive princess—a little like Siavash’s mommy, although she didn’t really get that story when mommy Mariam tried to explain it to her. Besides, her friend Abrangih, she is living in mother Gordiyag’s quarters. So, that alone makes her definitely a princess!

—“I’m sorry, Abrangih, I shouldn’t have said that. Of course you’re a princess. You’re one of us!”

The girl probably is not too keen on sitting alone either, and so she quickly hugs Borān. But before he can say something to her, Abrangih dashes away. That little imp. He’s going to have to wait another day before finding out who she really is. And just as he wants to leave too, the *Bāmbishn*

signals him.

—“Greek historiography has erroneously attested the battle against Queen Taumuriyah—the rendition Taumiraspena, a clever *dvandva*—, Queen of the Massagetān—notwithstanding that their rendition as Massive Goths is more dubious—, to be dated 1,134 years ago,” that’s how you know how special she is: any normal person would say a thousand years ago. And also, how you know she’s right, “to be in the Kur valley in the north, instead of the actual locale, near the Syr Daryā river in the east. Additionally, the mausoleum of the fallen *Shāhān-Shāh* Kurosh, while possibly a cenotaph, stands in Pasargadae in Pars.”

He only understands one quart, as usual, of what the *Bāmbishn* tells him. But her close scrutiny always feels reassuring and he wears her corrections as a badge of honor.

—“Oh, *spās* [thanks], Your Majesty. I will make note of that.”

Truthfully, he has not yet done that, but he should: write it all down. And perhaps one day, people would want to read the thousand stories of Varaztirots the Armenian, ha, ha.